

Nails in Every Type

Natural nail shapes, growth patterns, and reading health signals accurately across every skin tone

Learning Objectives

- Identify natural nail bed shapes and plate curvatures without treating any as a flaw
- Explain why vertical ridging usually increases with age, and when it is a genuine concern
- Accurately read nail bed colour and capillary refill across the full range of skin tones
- Avoid diagnostic techniques that were only ever calibrated on fair skin

Structure varies. None of it needs fixing

Nail beds are naturally wide or narrow, short or long, flat or noticeably curved, and every variation is exactly that — a variation, not a deviation from some ideal to be corrected with aggressive filing or shape "improvement." This module teaches you to see structure accurately, and to read health signals accurately across every skin tone your chair will ever hold.

Natural nail bed shapes

- **Oval / almond nail beds** — a naturally tapered bed, often suited to almond or oval free-edge shaping.
- **Square nail beds** — a wider, flatter bed, often suited to square or squoval shaping.
- **Curved (highly convex) nail plates** — a natural, genetically influenced curvature, not a sign of a problem, though it can make certain artificial extensions more technically demanding to apply evenly.

Recommend a free-edge shape that complements the client's natural bed shape and finger length, per Module Eleven — never impose a single "correct" shape onto every client regardless of what her hands actually are.

Ridging: usually age, occasionally a signal

Fine vertical ridges running the length of the nail plate become more common with age as cell turnover at the matrix slows slightly — this is normal and, on its own, not a cause for concern. Horizontal ridges or grooves (Beau's lines), by contrast, can indicate the nail growth was disrupted by illness, injury, or significant stress at a specific point in time, and deserve a gentle conversation, covered further in Module Three.

◆ Figure 2.1 · Vertical Ridging vs. Beau's Lines



Vertical ridging · usually just age



Beau's line · a disruption worth asking about

Direction matters: vertical is usually cosmetic ageing; a single horizontal groove marks a specific past disruption to growth.

Reading colour accurately across skin tones

Nail bed colour is a genuinely useful health indicator — but only if you know how to read it correctly on the skin tone in front of you. Diagnostic shorthand like "look for a pink nail bed" or "check for blue-tinted nails" was historically calibrated almost entirely on fair skin, and applied uncritically, it fails deeper skin tones exactly the way the shade ranges in Course III failed them.

- **On fair to medium skin**, pallor, blueness (cyanosis), or unusual redness are usually visible directly in the nail bed itself.
- **On deep skin tones**, these same changes can be far less visible in the nail bed and are read more reliably at the nail beds' lighter areas, the lunula, or by comparing directly against the client's own established baseline rather than a generic pink reference.

- **Capillary refill** (gently pressing the nail tip until it pales, then timing the return of colour — normally under two to three seconds) remains a reliable test across all skin tones, since it measures a change in blood flow rather than absolute colour.

Never tell a client with deep skin tone that her nail beds are "hard to read" as if the limitation belongs to her. The limitation belongs to a diagnostic habit trained on too narrow a range — and this module exists to correct that habit permanently.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Baseline Record

On a partner or model, identify natural nail bed shape, note any ridging observed, and practice a capillary refill test, recording the return time. Establish and write down this client's personal colour baseline. **Keep this record for your consultation practice in Module Ten.**